Leftover Bytes

(Stakeholder Insights, Strategy & Roles)

Team Members (Product Managers)

Samritha Aadhi Ravikumar
(UX/UI & Creative Product Design Lead)

Akshara Ramprasad
(Stakeholder & Partnerships Lead)

Amruth Devineni
(Technical & Product Strategy Coordinator)

Rishabh Reddy Suravaram
(User Research & Feedback Lead)

Aashrey Jain
(Project Manager & Operations Lead)

Stakeholders Checkbox

Approach 1:
First-Come, First-Serve (Most Feasible)

Event organizers upload a photo of leftover food right after the event. A real-time notification is sent to all BU students nearby (Babcock to Blandford), encouraging immediate pickup. Fast, simple, and highly efficient.

Approach 2:
Manual Distribution (Not Feasible)

Organizers stay back to distribute fixed portions to students and update the app with food availability in real time. Labor-intensive and difficult to scale.

Approach 3:
Camera-Based Monitoring (Not Feasible)

Install cameras at food stations to monitor leftovers and auto-update the app every 5–10 minutes. No human effort, but costly and impractical to implement widely.

Stakeholders	Approach 1	Approach 2	Approach 3
Sarah Healey	✅	❌	✅
Alessandra	✅	❌	❌

Stakeholder 1 - Sarah (Zero Waste Manager)

Ques 1: Can you provide us the details of people to contact who organize lots of events?

Ans: Not really, events are organised within the university people and from outside as well.

Ques 2: As we would be sending notifications by building this App and make it centralised. Would BU want it to be monetized and generate revenue?

Ans: Not really like it to be monetized.

Discussion and Feedback Summary

Preferred Approaches:

She liked Approach 1 (First-Come-First-Serve) and Approach 3 (leftovers relocated to a central spot with webcam access).

Approach 1 Notes:

- Contact Spark as they're already collaborating with BU Dining.
- She **appreciated the app idea with dietary restrictions** included.

Approach 3 Notes:

- Found it interesting but **feasibility is a concern** due to multiple events in different locations.
- Central relocation of food may not work practically.

Food Waste Insights:

- She can **provide waste bin data and dashboard access** showing food waste insights.
- Currently, Slack is used to notify leftover food, but it's unstructured.

High Food Waste Locations:

- **Floors 11, 16, and 17** frequently host events and have **abundant leftovers.**

New Suggestions:

- Use the app to **share screenshots of leftover food** to help others decide if it's worth grabbing.
- Allow people collecting food to send updates via the app.

Additional Insight:

- Despite an existing app, **food is still getting wasted.**
- She is interested in using the new app to **track number of meals left** and provide more detailed statistics.

Stakeholder 2 - Alessandra (CAS Event Manager)

Ques 1: Should we build an app or a website?

Ans: Discussing about this we ended up with website being a better alternative because it is more cost effective and we can collaborate with other team in BU Spark who is working with BU Dining.

Ques 2: As we would be sending notifications by building this App and make it centralised. Would BU want it to be monetized and generate revenue?

Ans: Not really like it to be monetized. However, she would really like to promote and popularize it more so that more people can come and grab leftover food and reduce food wastage

Discussion and Feedback Summary

Preferred Approaches:

She preferred Approach 1 (First-Come-First-Serve).

Event Coordination:

- Shared the **CDS Calendar with event details** (dates, locations) to help contact organizers in advance.
- Organizers can send **screenshots of leftover food** post-event.
- Advised discussing Stakeholder 1 feedback for further improvements.
- Suggested reaching out to BU Spark about their events.

High Food Waste Locations:

- **Floors 16, and 17** have frequent events and high food waste.

New Suggestions:

- Introduced a **BU Points system to reward** active users for posting food updates.
- Top contributors can earn **certificates**.
- Shared a **point of contact** to discuss certificate issuance.

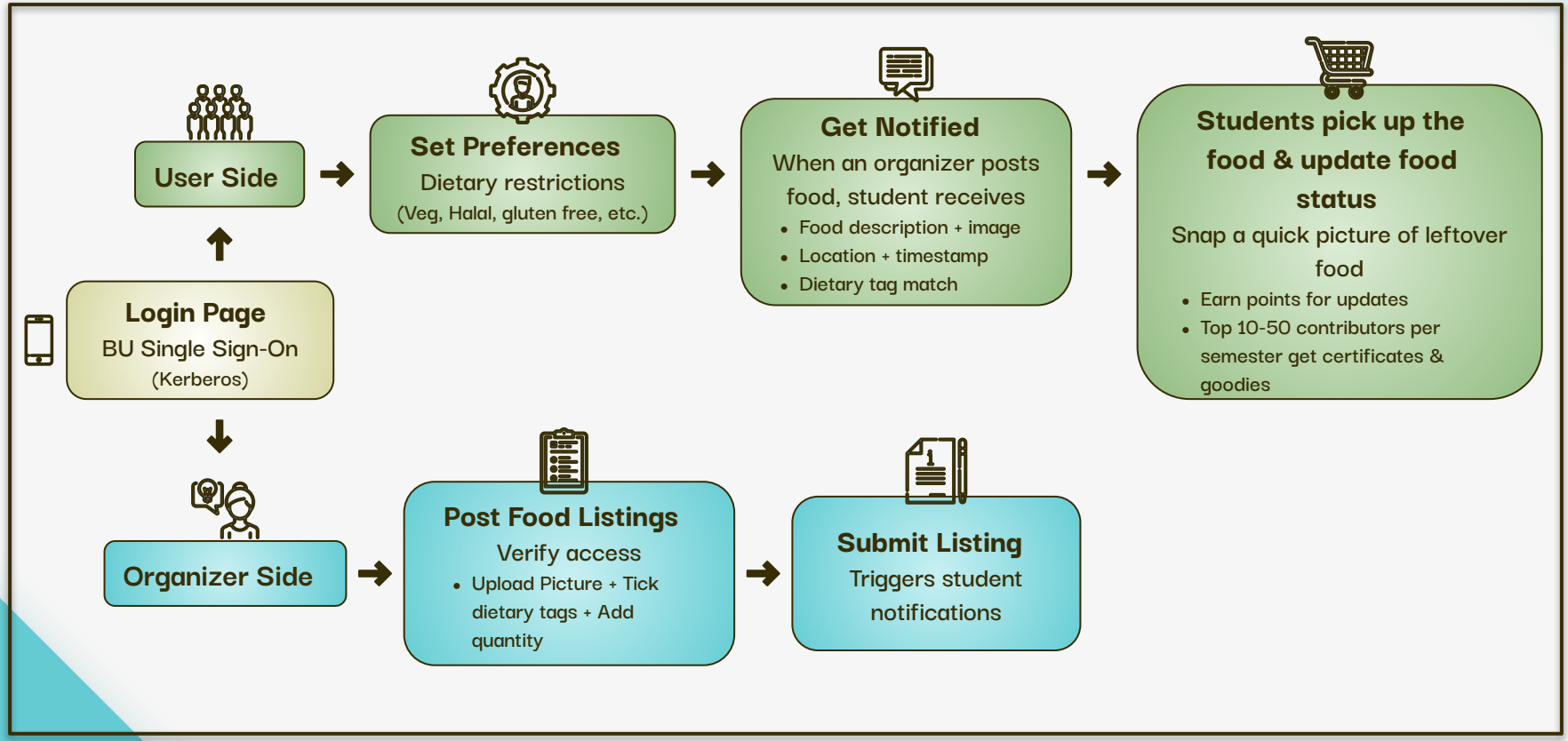
Website vs App Dilemma

Criteria	Website	Mobile App
Accessibility	No install needed	Persistent & quick access
Notifications	Email/browser-based	Real-time push notifications
Photo Uploads	Slower on browser	One-tap uploads via phone
Engagement	Lower (transactional use)	Higher via gamification + leaderboards
Organizer Usage	Easy via browser	Better handled through web dashboard

Why We Chose to Build an App:

- Students are always mobile – they need real-time alerts they can act on immediately.
- Uploading food updates is faster and easier via a phone camera.
- The app supports a points system, leaderboard, and rewards for active users.

Flowchart


User Side
Set Preferences
Dietary restrictions
(Veg, Halal, gluten free, etc.)
Get Notified
When an organizer posts food, student receives
Food description + image
Location + timestamp
Dietary tag match
Students pick up the food & update food status
Snap a quick picture of leftover food
Earn points for updates
Top 10-50 contributors per semester get certificates & goodies
Login Page
BU Single Sign-On
(Kerberos)
Organizer Side
Post Food Listings
Verify access
Upload Picture + Tick dietary tags + Add quantity
Submit Listing
Triggers student notifications

Strategy

Pilot at CDS Events (4/day) for Feedback & Validation
We'll begin with a student-facing **mobile app prototype**, tested at CDS events where leftover food is frequent. This phase helps us gather data on student behavior, food posting frequency, and engagement with notifications.

Real-Time Push Notifications via App
Students receive **instant alerts** when food is posted. Alerts include: food description, dietary tags, photo, location, and freshness timestamp — all tailored to the user's preferences.

Community Updates & Gamification
Students can upload photos of remaining food to help others decide whether to go. These updates **earn points**, and top contributors are featured on a **leaderboard** with rewards like **certificates**(Active Community Member) or goodies.

Dietary Preference-Based Filtering
Students opt in and select dietary preferences (vegetarian, halal, gluten-free, etc.). Notifications are **personalized** to reduce spam and increase match quality.

Location-Based Alerts
Notifications are prioritized for students **closest to the event location**, increasing the chance that food is picked up quickly and not wasted.

Vision

1 **Product Vision**

To build a sustainable, efficient, and equitable platform that notifies students about leftover food from campus events—minimizing waste and supporting food-insecure students.

2 **Why this matters?**

- Builds a culture where **food is shared, not wasted.**
- Advances BU's **zero-waste and sustainability goals**
- Promotes environmental sustainability through campus partnerships.

3 **Long-Term Goal**

A university ecosystem where no food goes to waste, and every student has access to healthy meals.

North Star Metric

Weekly percentage of leftover food successfully claimed and picked up

Pickup Success Rate (%) = (Number of portions picked up ÷ Total portions listed) × 100

Mission-Aligned

Directly measures the success of food redistribution—our core goal.

Behavioral Insight

Tells us which events, food types, and timings yield the highest engagement.

Tactical Insight

Helps us optimize logistics, such as best times to notify and how many portions go unused.

Strategic Value

Guides long-term product direction—what features improve pickup success, how to scale to other departments, and what partnerships matter most.

User Impact

Measures real-world impact on students, not vanity metrics like app downloads.

Responsible Accountable Consulted Informed Chart

Responsibilities	Project Manager & Operations	Stakeholders & Partnerships	Tech & Product Strategy	UX/UI & Content Design	User Research & Feedback
Stakeholder Outreach & Coordination	R	A	I	I	C
Team Management & Planning	A	I	C	I	R
End-user Research & Feedback Collection	R	C	C	C	A
Define Product Features & MVP Strategy	C	C	A	C	R
App Flow Design & Wildframes	I	I	R	A	C
Presentation & Communication	C	A	R	R	C

Team Needed to Build Product

Role	Needed For
BU Spark / CDS Admin	Institutional support, access to pilot events
BU Sustainability	Certificate rewards, data insights
Catering on the Charles	Policy & food safety input
App Developer (Mobile)	Student-facing app (both IOS & Android)
Backend Developer	Authentication, food listing, notifications
UX/UI Designer	Interface for students and organizers
Our Team	Strategy, coordination, interviews, testing & feedback

End-Users Interview Questions

We have spoken to some of the students & Lauren(Saxby's manager) to schedule the interview upcoming week !!!

Students

Section 1: General Food Access Habits

1. How often do you attend BU events with leftover food?
2. Have you wanted to be notified about leftover food?
3. Do you face challenges with food access or budgeting?

Section 2: Notifications & Preferences

1. Preferred alert method:
   App / Website / Text/Email / Other
2. Would you use a platform to claim nearby leftovers?
3. Comfortable adding dietary preferences for personalized alerts?

Section 3: Concerns & Suggestions

1. Any concerns with using a food-sharing app? (e.g., safety, fairness)
2. What features would make it more useful or enjoyable?

Event Organizers

Section 1: Current Practices

1. How often do you organize food-related events?
2. What happens to leftover food?
3. Do you currently notify students/staff about leftovers? How?

Section 2: Platform Interest

1. Would a platform to notify students be helpful?
2. Willing to list leftovers on a dashboard?
3. What would make listing easy? (photos, checkboxes, templates)
4. How much time do you have after events to list leftovers?

Section 3: Food Info & Safety

1. Can you provide basic food info? (type, dietary tags)
2. Any concerns about sharing leftovers? (e.g., safety, liability)
3. Would templates or reminders make listing easier?

Thank You!